

First clashes

The battle itself was a close-run affair. McDowell's flanking movements were delayed by defective staffwork and inexperience, while an aggressive defense by Confederate units on the left flank gave the Confederates crucial time to ward off the Union commander's attempt to turn them.

Beauregard at first dreamed of a Confederate offensive, but confusing orders and poor staffwork resulted more in bewilderment than anything else. Foreshadowing problems that would persist throughout much of the war, Union forces struggled to coordinate their assaults, and instead of amassing their strength to take a position, the individual units (in this case, single regiments) made their attacks piecemeal. Even so, the battle went well for the Union forces in the early part of the day, as they pushed past Matthews Hill down toward Henry Hill, threatening to turn the Confederate left.

In the end, however, all the delays and lack of coordination allowed the Confederates to man a powerful defensive position on Henry Hill, where the battle finally reached its climax. It was here that Brigadier General Thomas J. Jackson earned his nickname, "Stonewall," for his well-handled and vital defense of the position.

“Let us **determine** to die here,
and **we will conquer. Rally**
behind the Virginians.”

ATTRIBUTED TO BRIGADIER GENERAL BARNARD E. BEE, CONFEDERATE
ARMY

Federal disorder

Johnston, having only recently arrived, fed Confederate troops into this crucial site, and the Union side continued to waste its strength in badly organized assaults. Two Union batteries held important positions on the hill, but one was mauled by a Confederate regiment